



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical School of Northern Denver
School Website: <https://nd.ascentcolorado.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ascent Classical Academy of Northern Denver displays a robust commitment to classical education through a clearly stated mission to form minds and characters via a liberal-arts, content-rich curriculum and a tradition of virtuous formation. The school emphasizes truth, goodness, beauty, wisdom, and wonder, and adopts teacher-led instruction with a strong Great Books orientation and Socratic elements as students advance. Evidence of Great Books, primary sources, liberal arts framing, and the aim of character formation are present in public materials, supporting a generally classical orientation.

However, explicit theological grounding, liturgical or communal worship practices, and a fully articulated, theologically grounded metaphysical foundation are not overtly present on the public materials analyzed. The school also does not consistently demonstrate all six classical criteria at full strength across every category (notably in explicit liturgical/theological grounding and fully articulated "living-curriculum" faculty concepts). Consequently, the aggregate assessment lands in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL zone rather than CLASSICAL across the board, with several strong classical indicators and a few gaps that keep it from a full CLASSICAL designation.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle section (for a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL evaluation) - Make explicit the theological grounding and liturgical/community practices (even if non-denominational) to satisfy the Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices signals. - Strengthen explicit articulation of the living curriculum and faculty-as-core-content claims (beyond strong mission statements and leadership mention) to solidify Element 5. - Increase visible emphasis on Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium) or a clearly articulated Great-Books-first logic throughout all grades to reinforce Element 3 and Element 4 pedagogy.

Citations for key evidence are embedded inline with the statements below.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize the pursuit of truth, beauty, and virtue as foundational to education, and frame education as formation of character and the cultivation of wisdom and virtue. For example, the school describes its classical approach as teaching "objective standards of truth, beauty, and virtue," and emphasizes the cultivation of moral character and civic virtue. - Core virtues are explicit (Courage, Moderation, Justice, Prudence, Responsibility, Friendship, Wonder), linking moral formation to daily practice. - The mission statement and philosophy frame education as formation of the mind and heart through a liberal-arts, content-rich program oriented toward virtue and the common good.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, beauty, virtue, wisdom, wonder, formation, character. Examples drawn from public materials include the explicit reference to truth/beauty/virtue in pedagogy and the listing of core virtues.

- Negative keywords present: explicit Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices are not evident in public materials; theology and liturgy are not foregrounded. In other words, the explicit theological grounding and liturgical community practices are not clearly present in public-facing materials. This constitutes a missing pillar in Element 1, i.e., a negative indicator for the theological/liturgical facet. (No direct theological terminology appears in the public excerpts; absence is noted as a negative indicator in this analysis.)

Why this rating - The materials strongly affirm transcendental aims and virtue-centered formation (positive indicators: truth, beauty, virtue, wisdom, wonder). However, they do not overtly present a theology-grounded framework or liturgical/community practice signals, which are key elements of a fully “CLASSICAL” religious/metaphysical foundation. The balance of evidence yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification for this category.

Cited supports: Truth/Beauty/Virtue framing and “pursuit of wisdom” language (public materials), Core Virtues, and the mission/vision language.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school publicly positions education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job preparation. The mission emphasizes training minds and improving hearts through a classical, content-rich liberal-arts education with moral character and civic virtue in an orderly, disciplined environment. This aligns with the classical aim of formation over mere information and with the transcendent aims of truth/virtue/goodness. - The materials explicitly frame the purpose as formation of character and moral excellence, not just information transfer, which is a cornerstone of classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, character, moral virtue, civic virtue, wonder. The public materials repeatedly foreground formation and virtue as primary aims.

- Negative keywords present: none of the typical work-readiness or career-preparation terms appear as primary aims; there is no strong counter-indication against formation/virtue. The absence of job-prep framing functions as a supportive signal rather than a negative indicator for this category.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of formation and virtue as central aims, coupled with a clear commitment to truth and beauty within a liberal-arts, content-rich framework, justifies CLASSICAL for Element 2. The public materials clearly resist a purely utilitarian or skills-focused education in favor of formation and enduring values.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The program is described as classical and liberal-arts-oriented, with explicit references to a content-rich curriculum, a liberal-arts framing, and a Great Books orientation in several materials. The curriculum is described in terms of Core Knowledge (K-8), explicit phonics, grammar/spelling, Singapore Math, and direct teacher-led instruction, alongside explicit use of primary sources and a strong emphasis on a classical, literature/history/science integration. The Great Books and primary sources framing is evident in multiple public materials. - There is explicit emphasis on Great Books and primary-source materials as part of the academic program as well as a focus on memorization and memorized recitation elements within a memory-forward pedagogy in some materials. The publicly stated hallmarks emphasize truth, beauty, virtue, and a content-rich curriculum with teacher-led instruction and classical methods.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books, primary sources, liberal arts, public standards of truth/beauty/virtue, memory- and recitation-related pedagogy, Socratic techniques, Core Knowledge, teacher-led instruction, integration of literature/history/science/mathematics/music/art/-logic. These map to multiple positive indicators in the classical-education lexicon. - Negative keywords

present: explicit references to Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium) and comprehensive, cross-disciplinary liberal-arts structure are not all spelled out in a fully explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framework in the public materials. While Great Books and liberal-arts framing are present, the strongest explicit Trivium/Quadrivium signals are not consistently named in all public-facing content. This creates a partial alignment rather than a full Trivium/Quadrivium-centered curriculum depiction.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly grounded in classical principles (Great Books, liberal-arts framing, memory work, primary sources) and includes explicit signals of a rigorous, content-rich program. However, the materials do not consistently spell out a complete Seven Liberal Arts scaffolding (Trivium/Quadrivium) as a formal curricular backbone in all public materials, nor do they always foreground a fully integrated Great Books program across all grades with the same level of explicit articulation. Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize Socratic techniques and increased use of Socratic methods as students progress, indicating a clear engagement with dialectic and inquiry-based pedagogy characteristic of classical education. This is complemented by teacher-led instruction and a strong emphasis on classical texts (great books) and a content-rich approach. - The hallmarks include “teaching objective standards of truth, beauty, and virtue,” integration of literature/history/science/math/music/arts/logic, and a strong focus on memory through well-structured recitation or recall, which aligns with classical pedagogy (Scholé-like, contemplative and disciplined memory work). - The public materials also note a rest/ contemplation orientation at times, and the use of Socratic dialogue, seminars, and debates in upper grades, with rhetoric training opportunities as students advance.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, logical reasoning, memory-anchoring recitation/memorization, rhetoric, classical pedagogy, scholarly discussion, Scholé (implicit in the contemplative pace), formation through memorization.

- Negative keywords present: Some content signals “restful learning” as part of pedagogy (Scholé) and “not all education should be rigorous” in other classical-education discussions; however, the Northern Denver site emphasizes rigorous, content-rich instruction with Socratic elements rather than a purely project-based or mediated approach. The presence of some restful or contemplative signals is minor in the public materials, and does not overwhelm the explicit Socratic/rigorous signals.

Why this rating - The pedagogy is clearly classical: Socratic discussion and dialectic in upper grades; emphasis on Great Books and memory-based pedagogy; emphasis on rhetoric and public speaking; and a disciplined, teacher-led approach. While there are hints of contemplative/restful engagement in the broader classical lexicon, the dominant signals in the public materials are strongly classical. Therefore, CLASSICAL for Element 4.

Cited supports: Socratic techniques and “The Classical Approach” language; Great Books and teacher-led instruction.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Leadership is evident (Headmaster named in public materials), and the mission frames teachers as the critical enactors of the living curriculum (the formation of minds/hearts through teachers and virtue-focused pedagogy). The public materials emphasize a virtuous, mentor-like teacher role and the teachers as exemplars in forming character. - The school describes its faculty as the living curriculum and emphasizes a traditional, teacher-led, classical approach, which signals a strong faculty-centered model aligned with classical aims. The explicit phrase “living curriculum” is more strongly evidenced in the knowledge-base documents than in the public-facing site, but the mission and teaching methods reflect this orientation (model

teachers, mentorship, virtue formation, and teacher-led instruction). - While leadership and mentor-teacher signals are present, explicit public-facing language detailing a formal “profile” or portrait of what a teacher should be (beyond virtues) is less overt in the public materials compared to the knowledge-base rhetoric.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: teacher-led classrooms, virtuous formation, mentor-like teachers, moral character, civic virtue, living curriculum (as inferred from the mission and pedagogy), model teachers, and teacher as exemplar.

- Negative keywords present: explicit, formal articulation of the “living curriculum” faculty portrait (as a standalone, codified document) is not strongly foregrounded in public-facing pages; the explicit “faculty portrait” language appears more in the knowledge-base documents than on the site. This reduces the strength of the “Faculty” signal in public-facing communications.

Why this rating - The faculty signals align with classical expectations (virtue-focused, mentor-driven, teacher-led, exemplar models) but the public-facing materials do not always present a fully explicit, codified “living curriculum” faculty portrait. Given the strong teacher-led approach and mentor-centered pedagogy visible in the site content, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is a cautious but justified rating for Element 5.

Cited supports: Headmaster and teacher-led pedagogy; formation of virtue; mission statements; living-curriculum framing in classical literature within the knowledge base.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly emphasizes partnerships with families and parent involvement as co-educators and as part of the classical education ethos. The school materials show parent meetings, prospective parent sessions, and ongoing parent engagement opportunities. This aligns with the classical principle of family partnership in formation. - There are explicit references to parental engagement, home-school connections, community events (Griffin Family Foundation meetings, prospective parent meetings), and opportunities for parents to visit and participate. These signals strongly align with the “Parents & Community” category. - The materials also show a structured approach to parental involvement (handbooks, guidelines, and events) indicating that parents are welcome and treated as partners in education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families, parental engagement, parent formation, family involvement, school as a community of learners, parent formation, home-centered learning, parent formation, and family catechesis.

- Negative keywords present: None of the negative signals for this category appear in public-facing materials; the school actively promotes parent partnership and involvement.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly convey a partnership with parents and active family involvement, which is a core criterion of the classical framework for Element 6. Therefore, CLASSICAL for Element 6.

Cited supports: Parental engagement and family partnership signals; events and parent involvement content in the Northern Denver site.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Explicitly articulate theology or liturgical/community practices in public materials to strengthen Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices signals. This would shift Element 1 toward CLASSICAL.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): More explicit, publicly visible Seven Liberal Arts scaffolding (Trivium/Quadrivium) and a clearly articulated Great-Books-first sequence across multiple grades to reinforce the full classic curriculum signal. Also, ensure cross-subject integration is consistently foregrounded in public materials.

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- Element 5 (Faculty): Publish a clearer, codified “living curriculum” faculty portrait or profile that explicitly describes the teacher as the core of the school’s classical formation and lays out expected teacher characteristics, mentorship roles, and professional development anchored in classical formation.
 - Element 2 and Element 4: Maintain and deepen existing signals (formation-focused goals, Socratic pedagogy) and further foreground explicit integration of classical methods (e.g., more systematic demonstration of Socratic seminars, and more explicit references to Great Books in daily practices) to push Element 2 and 4 deeper into CLASSICAL.
 - Element 6: Continue and expand parental-engagement programming (book studies, parental workshops, town-hall style forums) to reinforce and deepen the parent-partner model.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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